Consultant rota → your calendar

A step-by-step setup guide for colleagues. No coding needed.

About **20 minutes** of one-off setup puts your rota shifts into your own calendar, updated automatically every morning. Every step is clicking and copy-pasting in a web browser.

What you end up with: all-day events for each shift, colour-coded **orange** (Service), **red** (On Call) and **yellow** (CoMET), with "(Locum)" added for locum shifts. If the rota changes, your calendar follows within a day.

How it works: a small program on a free website called GitHub reads the rota each morning, finds your name and writes your shifts into a Google calendar. Outlook and iPhone users then subscribe to that calendar (Step 6).

At a glance

1	2	3	4	5	6
GitHub account	Copy the program	Rota calendar	Your 3 secrets	Switch on & test	Google / Outlook / iPhone

Before you start, have these ready

- ☐ A **computer** with a web browser (a phone works but is fiddly).
- ☐ A **Google account**. A free Gmail address is fine, even if you normally use Outlook.
- ☐ From Alex: the **key file** (a small text file ending in `.json`) and the **robot email address** (ending `.iam.gserviceaccount.com`). Keep the key file private, like a password.
- ☐ Your **first name exactly as written in the rota** (e.g. "Charlotte", not "Charlie").

> **Tip:** Open this guide on one side of the screen and your browser on the other. **Bold words** are exactly what you will see on screen to click.

1 Create a free GitHub account

GitHub stores the program and runs it on a timer for free, even when your computer is off.

1. Go to **github.com/signup**.
2. Enter any email address, choose a password and pick a username (e.g. `jane-smith`).
3. Complete the puzzle and type in the code GitHub emails you.
4. If asked to choose a plan, choose **Free**. Skip any other questions.

2 Make your own copy (a “fork”)

Your copy is yours alone. Your details never touch Alex's version.

1. While logged in, go to **github.com/dewar14/consultant-rota-scraper**.
2. Near the top right, click **Fork**.
3. On the “Create a new fork” page, change nothing and click the green **Create fork** button.
4. Check the web address now starts with `github.com/` followed by **your** username, not `dewar14`. Keep this tab open.

3 Make a rota calendar and let the robot write to it

Use a separate calendar, not your main one: the robot then only ever sees the rota, and it is the safe way to share shifts with Outlook or an iPhone.

1. Go to **calendar.google.com**, signed in to your Google account.
2. On the left, next to **Other calendars**, click **+** then **Create new calendar**.
3. Name it `Consultant rota` and click **Create calendar**.
4. On the left, under **Settings for my calendars**, click **Consultant rota**.
5. Scroll to **Share with specific people or groups** and click **Add people and groups**.
6. Paste the **robot email address** from Alex.
7. Set **Permissions** to **Make changes to events** and click **Send**. If warned it is outside your organisation, confirm.
8. Scroll down to **Integrate calendar** and copy the **Calendar ID** (a long jumble ending `@group.calendar.google.com`). Paste it into a note for Step 4.

> **Most common mistake:** the permission must say **Make changes to events**. “See all event details” will not work.

4 Add your three secrets on GitHub

"Secrets" are private settings your copy can read but nobody else can see, including Alex.

1. Back in your GitHub tab, click **Settings** (top row of tabs, far right).
2. In the left menu, click **Secrets and variables**, then **Actions**.
3. Click the green **New repository secret** button. Type the **Name** exactly as below, paste the value into **Secret**, and click **Add secret**. Repeat for all three.

Name (type exactly)	**What to paste in**
`MY_NAME`	Your first name exactly as written in the rota, e.g. `Charlotte`
`CALENDAR_ID`	The Calendar ID you copied in Step 3, ending `@group.calendar.google.com`
`GOOGLE_CREDENTIALS_JSON`	The whole contents of Alex's key file (see below)

To copy the key file: right-click it and open it with **Notepad** (Windows) or **TextEdit** (Mac). Press Ctrl+A (Cmd+A on a Mac) to select everything, copy, and paste. It should start with `{` and end with `}`.

Check: the page now lists all three names. The values show as hidden – that is normal.

5 Switch it on and run a test

GitHub keeps the timer off on new copies, so you switch it on once and test straight away.

1. In your GitHub tab, click the **Actions** tab at the top.
2. Click the green **I understand my workflows, go ahead and enable them** button.
3. In the left-hand list, click **Daily Rota Sync**.
4. On the right, click **Run workflow**, then the green **Run workflow** button that appears.
5. Wait about a minute and refresh. The spinning circle turns into a **green tick** (worked) or a **red cross** (see Troubleshooting on the last page).

Green tick? Open Google Calendar and tick **Consultant rota** on the left. Your next 16 weeks of shifts should be there. It now runs by itself every morning at about 07:00 in winter and 08:00 in summer (sometimes up to an hour late).

6 See the shifts where you look at your diary

The shifts always land in your Google “Consultant rota” calendar first. Pick the option that matches you.

Option A – Google Calendar (including Android)

Nothing more to do. Make sure **Consultant rota** is ticked. On your phone, open the Google Calendar app, go to **Settings** and switch the calendar on if it is hidden.

Option B – Outlook (or any app that takes an “iCal link”)

Outlook follows a private web link to your rota calendar. It is one-way and read-only, and Outlook may take several hours to pick up changes.

1. In Google Calendar: **Settings for my calendars → Consultant rota → Integrate calendar**.
2. Copy the **Secret address in iCal format** (ends in `.ics`). Treat it like a password.
3. **Outlook web or new Outlook:** in the calendar view click **Add calendar → Subscribe from web**, paste the link, name it `Consultant rota`, click **Import**. **Classic Outlook: File → Account Settings → Internet Calendars → New**.

> **NHS.net or work Outlook:** if the subscribe option is missing or refuses the link, IT may have blocked internet calendars. Use a personal Outlook or Option A instead.

Option C – iPhone, iPad or Mac

Simplest: add your Google account to the device. On iPhone: **Settings → Calendar** (or **Apps → Calendar**) → **Calendar Accounts → Add Account → Google**. Sign in and leave **Calendars** switched on. Updates arrive quickly.

Without adding your Google account: use the iCal link from Option B. iPhone: **Add Account → Other → Add Subscribed Calendar**. Mac: **File → New Calendar Subscription**, and set **Auto-refresh** to every hour or every day.

Menu names change between versions. Official help: support.google.com/calendar/answer/37648 (Google) and support.microsoft.com – “See your Google Calendar in Outlook”.

If something goes wrong

To see why a run failed: **Actions** tab → click the red cross → **sync** → open the step with the red cross and read the error near the bottom.

What you see	Likely cause and fix
Error mentioning **404** or **403**	Calendar not shared with the robot, or wrong Calendar ID. Redo Step 3 (permission must be **Make changes to events**) and check `CALENDAR_ID` has no extra spaces.
Error mentioning **JSON** or credentials	Key file not pasted in full. Delete `GOOGLE_CREDENTIALS_JSON` and add it again, from the first `{` to the last `}`.
Green tick but “Found 0 shifts”	`MY_NAME` does not match the rota spelling, or you have no shifts in the next 16 weeks.
Green tick but nothing in your calendar	Check you are looking at **Consultant rota** and it is ticked. Outlook and iCal can lag by hours.
Stopped updating after a couple of months	GitHub pauses timers after 60 days of no activity. **Actions** → **Daily Rota Sync** → **Run workflow** once restarts it.
A shift is missing or wrong after a re-run	Message Alex with your name, the date and a screenshot of that part of the rota.

Good to know

- **Don't edit or delete rota events by hand** – the next run puts them back. Fix the rota and the calendar follows.
- **Your own events are never touched.** The sync only manages events described as “Scraped from RITA rota”.
- **To change a detail later: Settings** → **Secrets and variables** → **Actions**, click the pencil next to the secret, update it, then run the workflow once from **Actions**.
- **Stuck?** Message Alex with the step number, a screenshot and your GitHub username.